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Dear Mr. John Wu,

As you said in your 2015 commencement address, “Life should be an adventure. It is the very uncertainty that makes life interesting.”

At age 18, I was facing the death penalty after my parents outed me as gay, which is criminalized in Tunisia. While I was homeless and a fugitive, I worked as a server and cleaned bathrooms to afford library access. I used that access to teach myself English so I could write my college applications and submit them through public library computers, which earned me admission to Columbia University. I escaped to the United States as an international student with only the clothes on my back, and last month, I graduated from Columbia University with a Bachelor’s degree in Computer Science.

While studying and working in the United States, I came to understand immigration as a lifeline, one that determined not only whether I could work and remain, but whether I could continue building the life I had crossed an ocean to save. That struggle gave me more than perseverance. It gave me the insight, urgency, and conviction to build a company whose mission is inseparable from my own.

Drawing on years of experience in AI research and software engineering, I founded Ellis AI, named after New York’s historic gateway for immigrants. I want Ellis AI to offer immigrants the hope once embodied by the first sight of Ellis Island: the belief that beyond uncertainty, a new life remains possible.

My goal is to transform the legal barriers that once shaped every part of my life into a path that is clearer and more accessible for those who come after me. I ultimately chose to turn down an opportunity at Google and devote myself fully to building Ellis AI.

Ironically, my greatest barrier is not ambition, technical readiness, or commitment. It's my immigration status and the \$260,000 I must raise to build the company and support my O-1 petition. Your investment would give me more than capital. It would give me the chance to transform lived hardship into a company of lasting consequence and to build for immigrants whose futures are too often determined by systems they are left to navigate alone.

If given this opportunity, I will honor it with the same perseverance that carried me from surviving on the streets of Tunisia to graduating from Columbia University in New York. I know what it means to build with almost nothing, to continue when the outcome appears impossible, and to treat every opportunity as a responsibility. I will bring that same discipline, urgency, and gratitude to every dollar entrusted to me.

Thank you for considering my story, Ellis, and a future where AI helps immigrants carry their dreams across borders. I hope you will join me in building a world where technology turns uncertainty into possibility.

With utmost respect and gratitude,

Sammy Nawaly Abdella